

Microsoft under siege

A new worm, let loose on the Internet last month, infected Windows 2000 and XP systems by exploiting a security flaw. According to Symantec, around 423,000 systems were affected. Named the Blaster worm, it contained code to launch a scheduled DDOS attack on the windowsupdate.com site on August 16th. The worm was programmed to attack <http://windowsupdate.com>, from where Microsoft had been redirecting users to <http://windowsupdate.microsoft.com>, which is the actual URL. Eventually, it overcame the attack by disabling the automatic re-direction. A removal tool is available at <http://securityresponse1.symantec.com/sarc/sarc.nsf/html/w32.blaster.worm.removal.tool.html>.

A variant of the Blaster worm—Nachi—uses the same security hole to enter the host to remove the Blaster worm file. It then downloads the patch automatically from the Microsoft site and closes the security hole.

In another incident, a DOS attack on its premier site, Microsoft.com, caused it to be inaccessible for around two hours. Claiming that this was not an attack by the Blaster worm, the company officials said that they were investigating the occurrence together with the FBI.

snapshot

In **2003**, over **13 million smart phones** are expected to be sold—many of them powered by the **Symbian OS**

Source: IDC

Microsoft now atop your TV

Microsoft announced a tie-up with Time Warner Cable and Comcast Corp, which dominate the US cable TV market, to conduct field trials of its set-top box software. Time Warner will test TV Interactive Program Guide (IPG) software while Comcast will test Microsoft's TV Foundation Edition, along with IPG.

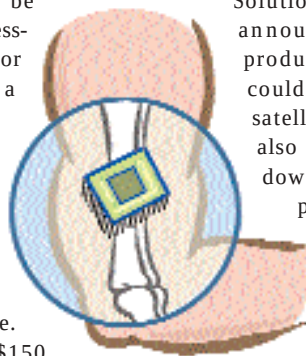
IPG enables users to find shows and customise viewing. On the other hand, the TV Foundation Edition allows operators to create channels that can be easily found and

bought by the consumers, as well as broadcast a variety of other services and applications such as games, news and weather updates. Another software—Microsoft TV Advanced—enables the cable to be shared as an Internet connection, thus saving cost to the consumer.

Microsoft has also signed up with three companies in Mexico, which have already begun sending out set-top boxes with Interactive Program Guide (IPG), Foundation Edition software and Microsoft TV Advanced.

Mexican rice-chips

Microchips that provide information ranging from identification to health records are now being sold in Mexico. The chip, dubbed as VeriChip, is the size of a rice grain and can be implanted painlessly in the arm or hip, using a syringe-like device. Health officials and security guards can read data stored on the chip using a scanning device. The chip costs \$150



and has an annual fee of \$50. The scanning device has a price tag of \$1,200. Currently, the chip can be tracked from a distance of 5 miles. But its developers, Applied Digital Solutions Inc, have announced plans to produce a chip that could be tracked using satellites. This would also help tracking down kidnapped people and missing individuals. This technology is already used in US for tracking pets.

SCO Updated

Santa Cruz Operation (SCO) has announced a license scheme to legalize their copy of Linux, according to which, all end-users using Linux kernel 2.4, or later, need to get the SCO Intellectual Property License. The prices vary from \$699 to run Linux on a single CPU server, to \$199 for a desktop PC. Incidentally, \$7.3



million of its revenues in the third quarter of this year came from its SCO source licensing division.

In a related development, Aduva Inc has come up with OnStage that removes any code violating the SCO license and downloads alternate code automatically.



heroes

Attaboy ATI!

Microsoft has teamed up with ATI to design graphics chips for the successor to the Xbox. ATI also has a similar deal with Nintendo to design graphics chips for the GameCube console.

Hypertransport

IBM, Texas Instruments, EMC and four other companies have joined the HyperTransport consortium—a move that will increase its usage. IBM has already used HyperTransport in its PowerPC 370 chip.



zeroes

GNU

For nearly three months, a cracker gained access to the primary FTP servers of the GNU project. The attack was discovered only in late July this year, but officials confirmed that no code was altered to insert any malicious code.

USB Sticks

The small and easy-to-use USB sticks have gained notoriety for being used to smuggle data from offices. Security firms are coming up with products to restrict their usage in workplaces.

OWN ONE?




Tell us more, and WIN!

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